

The Consolation of Philosophy



Boethius and his students depicted in an illuminated manuscript copy of *The Consolation of Philosophy*.

Around 524 CE, the Roman philosopher Boethius offered his thoughts on the problem of free will (see [Free will vs determinism](#)) in his book *The Consolation of Philosophy*, written while he was in prison awaiting execution on charges of treason. He presents his ideas as a conversation with Philosophy personified, who offers her wisdom to console him. They discuss virtue, justice and human nature, as well as free will and

predestination – the same subjects that concerned classical Greek philosophers.

Boethius was a Christian, and the book deals with many matters of faith, but it is significant that he found consolation in philosophy rather than religion. At this period, Christianity was beginning to assimilate philosophical ideas into its doctrine – philosophers such as Augustine and Boethius represented both the end of classical philosophy and the beginning of this process. That there was a place for philosophy in Christianity was confirmed by the continued influence of Boethius's work throughout the Middle Ages and into the Renaissance.